Sale was appalled. ‘All was confusion and indecision,’ she wrote. ‘The Envoy mounted his horse and rode to the gateway, and then rode back again?. . .’

Soon, however, Lady Sale had other matters to occupy her. Lieutenant Sturt, her new son-in-law, was brought on a stretcher from the Bala Hisar ‘covered with blood, and unable to articulate. From the wounds in the face and shoulder, the nerves were affected; the mouth would not open, the tongue was swollen and paralysed, and he was ghastly and faint from loss of blood. He could not lie down from the blood choking him. With some difficulty and great pain he was supported upstairs, and laid on a bed, when Dr Harcourt dressed his wounds, which having been inflicted about ten o’clock, now at one were cold and stiff with clotted blood.’[34]

While this was going on in the cantonment, Brigadier Shelton had belatedly marched his troops around the back of the city and into the Bala Hisar, but had been unsure what to do once he got there. Around 3 p.m. George Lawrence arrived back at Shah Shuja’s durbar and reported finding the unimaginative Shelton:

> directing a desultory fire on the city from two of his guns. Brig Shelton’s conduct at this crisis astonished me beyond expression . . . [He was] almost beside himself, not knowing how to act, and with incapacity stamped on every feature of his face. He immediately asked me what he should do, and on my replying ‘Enter the city at once,’ he sharply rebuked me, saying, ‘My force is inadequate, and you do not appear to know what street fighting is?. . .’ The King at this time asked me more than once why the troops did not act, and seemed to be, as well he might, deeply annoyed that we did nothing. Shelton well knew the King’s anxiety that he should take active measures for quelling the disturbance, but he was in fact quite paralysed . . .[35]

It was this paralysis which allowed a spontaneous protest by some disgruntled chiefs – one they imagined would be a hopeless gesture of anger, not the beginnings of a major revolution – to unite the people under the banner of Islam and grow quickly into one of the most dangerous challenges the British would face anywhere in their Empire in the nineteenth century. ‘Vacillation and incapacity ruled in our military counsels and paralysed the hearts of those who should have acted with energy and decision,’ concluded Lawrence. ‘By their deplorable pusillanimity an accidental emeute, which could have been quelled on the moment by the prompt employment of a small force, became a formidable insurrection, which ultimately involved the ruin of a gallant army.’[36]